

The application document checklist

Every document you actually need, organized by when it is due.

The core paperwork, explained

Transcript

An official record of your academic performance. For school students, this is usually sent by the school. For private candidates, universities may instead rely on your official Cambridge results, predicted grades, academic reference, and any additional documents they request.

Standardized test scores

If the school requires or accepts them, scores are usually sent directly from the testing agency, not simply typed into your application.

Letters of recommendation

Written by teachers or a counselor who can speak to who you are, not just your grades. These are requested from people with their own schedules, so timing matters here more than almost anywhere else.

Personal essay

Your main statement, usually submitted through the Common App, Coalition App, or UCAS, depending on where you are applying.

Supplemental essays

Extra, school specific writing on top of your main essay. Each school can have its own set, so these add up quickly across a longer list.

Activities list

A short summary of what you do outside class, ranked by how much it actually matters to you, not simply by title.

Financial aid forms

Forms like the CSS Profile or a school's own aid application, often due earlier than the admissions deadline itself.

The one line version

Most schools ask for the same handful of documents. Where students actually trip up is the timing, who submits what, and by when, not the documents themselves.

Why the deadlines matter more than the document itself

Several required documents are things you request from other people, a recommender, a school registrar, a testing agency, and those people have their own workloads and timelines. Waiting until close to your deadline to ask almost always causes avoidable problems.

Two separate things, your deadline and other people's deadlines

The school's deadline is when your complete file needs to arrive. Recommenders and school offices often need real lead time before that date just to do their part. Treat the published deadline as the very last moment things can arrive, not the moment you should start asking.

A suggested request timeline

When	What to do
2 to 3 months before	Ask teachers and your counselor for recommendation letters
6 to 8 weeks before	Request official transcripts from your school
4 to 6 weeks before	Finish a complete first draft of your main essay
2 to 3 weeks before	Complete supplemental essays for each individual school
1 to 2 weeks before	Submit financial aid forms, if required
Deadline day	Confirm every document has actually arrived, not just been sent

Important nuance

Submitted does not mean received. Always check each school's own applicant portal to confirm a document has actually arrived, rather than assuming it did because you sent it.

Quick myths vs reality

Myth: If I submit my application by the deadline, I am done.

Reality: Many schools allow supporting documents to arrive slightly after the main application deadline, while others do not. Check each school's specific document deadline rather than assuming they all match.

Myth: Recommendation letters can be requested any time before the deadline.

Reality: Teachers are often asked by many students at once close to deadlines. Asking early gives your letter more time, and usually more care.

Myth: Financial aid forms can wait until after I am admitted.

Reality: Forms like the CSS Profile often carry their own earlier deadline, separate from the admissions deadline, and missing it can cost you aid.

Building your checklist with this in mind

- Make one checklist per school, since exact document requirements differ slightly between them.
- Request every recommendation letter at least two months ahead of the earliest deadline.
- Track financial aid form deadlines separately from admissions deadlines.
- Confirm receipt of every document inside each school's own applicant portal, not just your sent folder.

Exact required documents and their deadlines vary by school. Always confirm the specific list on each school's own application requirements page.

sorted.